



A VESSEL floats in the distance in the Persian Gulf off the city of Sharjah, United Arab Emirates, Monday.

Blockade begins, threats multiply

Iran warns U.S.-allied countries that all ports in Persian Gulf and Oman Sea are at risk.

By SAMY MAGDY, JULIA FRANKEL AND MIKE CORDER

CAIRO — President Trump said Monday that the U.S. military had begun a blockade of Iranian ports as part of his effort to force Tehran to open the Strait of Hormuz and accept a deal to end the war that has raged for more than six weeks.

Iran responded with threats on all ports in the Persian Gulf and the Gulf of Oman, taking aim at U.S.-allied countries.

That set the stage for an extraordinary showdown that posed serious risks for the global economy and raised the specter that the ceasefire could collapse and the war could resume. Talks aimed at permanently ending the conflict — which began Feb. 28 with U.S. and Israeli strikes on Iran — failed to reach an agreement over the weekend. There has been no word on whether negotiations will resume.

Trump said the blockade started at 10 a.m. EDT.

“We can’t let a country blackmail or extort the world, because that’s what they’re doing,” Trump said of Iran.

Speaking outside the Oval Office, the president suggested the U.S. is still willing to engage with Iran.

“I can tell you that we’ve been called by the other side,” Trump said.

He added: “We’ve been called this morning by the right people, the appropriate people, and they want to work a deal.”

Trump did not say who called or what was discussed.

A notice to mariners by the U.K. Maritime Trade Operations agency said the blockade restricted “the entirety of the Iranian coast- [See Blockade, A3]

Cinemas emerge from pandemic’s doldrums

Recent box-office hits stir industry optimism

By SAMANTHA MASUNAGA

As movie theater owners and studio executives converge on Las Vegas this week for the annual CinemaCon trade conference, a rare sentiment is emerging — optimism.

A string of hits such as Amazon MGM Studios’ “Project Hail Mary” and Universal Pictures, Nintendo and Illumination’s “The Super Mario Galaxy Movie” have ignited theatrical revenue and helped push year-to-date domestic box-office revenue about 23% higher than a year earlier, according to Comscore data.

And that’s not just due to higher ticket prices. More people are going to theaters, with 154 million tickets sold this year in the U.S. and Canada, up nearly 16% from

the same time last year, data from Entertainment Intelligence shows.

The upswing suggests that the exhibition industry is beginning to recover from the devastating downturn that occurred in the aftermath of the COVID-19 pandemic when people got out of the habit of watching movies on the big screen and instead turned to Netflix and other streaming platforms.

Studio executives and theater operators chalk up the improved prospects to several factors, including a better and more plentiful crop of bankable movies that are giving consumers more reason to trek to the multiplex.

[See Cinemas, A11]



SCOTT A GARFITT Invision/AP

“PROJECT HAIL MARY” made its global premiere in London last month.

Trump slams pope, sparks backlash

Leo XIV defends Vatican’s repeated calls for peace

By GAVIN J. QUINTON AND JUSTINE MCDANIEL

WASHINGTON — President Trump was propelled into office in large part by support from evangelicals and Catholics, at times framing his political rise in divine terms.

But that relationship is now fraying, and, in some

corners of the Catholic Church, breaking, after Trump spent the weekend maligning Pope Leo XIV — “Leo is WEAK on Crime” — and circulating a widely condemned social media post depicting himself as Jesus Christ.

Leo, meanwhile, on Monday repeated his calls for an end of hostilities between the U.S. and Iran. “I have no

fear of neither the Trump administration nor of speaking out loudly about the message of the Gospel,” Leo told reporters. “Blessed are the peacemakers.”

Trump had lashed out at the pontiff in a Truth Social post on Sunday night and repeated those criticisms Monday. “I’m not a big fan of Pope Leo,” he said. “He’s a [See Pontiff, A7]

Swalwell steps down from his seat in House

The Democrat from the Bay Area faced expulsion threat over misconduct claims.

By ANA CEBALLOS AND BEN WIEDER

WASHINGTON — California Rep. Eric Swalwell resigned his congressional seat on Monday under intense pressure from lawmakers of both parties after several women accused him of sexual misconduct, including a former staffer who alleged rape.

Swalwell, a Dublin Democrat who suspended his campaign for California governor on Sunday, said in a statement that he was stepping down from the House, where he has served since 2013, and planned to continue fighting what he called “serious, false” allegations made against him.

“However, I must take responsibility and ownership of the mistakes I did make,” Swalwell wrote without specifying which mistakes those were.

His resignation came hours after the House Ethics Committee opened an inves-

tigation into the sexual misconduct allegations against him and as lawmakers from both parties threatened to expel him from the House if he did not leave his post. He said he was aware of the expulsion efforts underway and said that it was “wrong” to expel a member of Congress “without due process, within days of an allegation being made.”

“But it is also wrong for my constituents to have me distracted from my duties. Therefore, I plan to resign my seat in Congress,” he said.

Asked about replacing Swalwell, Gov. Gavin Newsom’s office said in a statement that it is “reviewing the matter. Once the seat is officially vacant, our office will make an official announcement.”

The allegations, detailed in reports by the San Francisco Chronicle and CNN last week, drew swift bipartisan condemnation, with lawmakers from both parties calling the accusations “disgusting” and demanding that he either resign or be removed from office.

Rep. Anna Paulina Luna (R-Fla.) intended to lead the [See Swalwell, A6]

Exit scrambles governor’s race as Democrats fret

By NICOLE NIXON, DAKOTA SMITH, MELODY GUTIERREZ AND SEEMA MEHTA

SACRAMENTO — The big-money backers and Democratic heavyweights who tried to crown Rep. Eric Swalwell as California’s next governor before his scandal-plagued exit from the political arena are now scrambling to find a new favorite among the candidates they either spurned or actively tried to undercut.

Swalwell (D-Dublin) announced Monday he would resign his seat in Congress. He faced potential expulsion and an ongoing criminal investigation after reports were made public Friday alleging he sexually assaulted a young female staff member and engaged in inappropriate behavior with three other women, including sending them nude photographs. Swalwell denied the allegations and, in his announcement Sunday that he was dropping out of the gov-

ernor’s race, vowed to fight to clear his name.

The immediate beneficiaries of Swalwell’s fall are likely former Orange County Rep. Katie Porter and billionaire financier Tom Steyer. Both were challenging Swalwell to be the top Democrat in the race even though each has faced attacks from within the party on various issues.

This new round of chaos only feeds the anxiety that has enveloped the California Democratic Party for months, stirred by fears that the lack of a singular party front-runner might lead to two Republicans winding up on the November ballot. Swalwell’s exit from the race also may revive candidates who have been languishing in the midsection of recent opinion polls — former U.S. Health and Human Services Secretary Xavier Becerra, former Los Angeles Mayor Antonio Villaraigosa and San José Mayor Matt Mahan — adding to the uncertainty.

“What happens now de- [See Supporters, A6]

He stared down unjust parking fine, and won

A court agreed \$93 ticket in Chinatown was wrong, but then penalty kept rising.

By FEDOR ZARKHIN

Paul Cook wasn’t about to fold — not with Mohandas Gandhi’s words ringing in his ears.

Never mind that the issue at the center of the David-versus-Goliath fight was a parking ticket that he could afford to pay. Never mind that if he was the David, then the Goliath was the Los Angeles Department of Transportation’s parking division, notoriously difficult to challenge. Never mind that even his friends told him fighting would be a waste of time.

“People are just, like, ‘You can’t win against them,’” Cook said. “For me, it’s just — it’s wrong.”

So drawing on Gandhi’s teachings about the unwavering power of righteous “soul strength” to overcome the greatest obstacles, Cook set forth on a journey through L.A.’s byzantine parking dispute process that would last some 16 months.

Cook’s story starts on Dec. 19, 2024, in Chinatown, when he returned to his car to find a yellow envelope tucked under his windshield wiper. Recalling the day in a recent interview with The Times, Cook quickly turns indignant about the bureaucratic odyssey that yellow slip launched. He’s mad not just because he feels his time was wasted, but also because he knows that many others without his legal background, perseverance or media savvy would simply pay the fine.

“The city of Los Angeles is unreasonable,” Cook told [See Ticket, A7]



AL SEIB Los Angeles Times

THE DEFUNCT Exide battery recycling facility.

Lead from Exide plant still lurks

Despite a decade of cleanup, study finds excessive amounts near — and not so near — the site. CALIFORNIA, B1

He’s like no doctor I’ve met

Trump’s explanation of his glowing, robbed portrait feels just a little off to columnist Steve Lopez. CALIFORNIA, B1

Weather

Mostly sunny. L.A. Basin: 74/53. B6

Stars oppose Paramount deal

A letter signed by more than 1,000 in Hollywood expresses concern about the Warner takeover. BUSINESS, A9

LAFD’s lesson on fighting PR fires

Here’s what consultants advised the agency after the Palisades blaze. CALIFORNIA, B1



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